

Adobe AIR:

Adobe AIR or Adobe Integrated Runtime, is a software development kit (SDK), which allows you bring your apps online. Using the AIR SDK, you can make installable applications with Flash and Flex using ActionScript, or using JavaScript and HTML. It is integrated well with Dreamweaver, and all you need to do is to export your app as an AIR file, and it's done!

The AIR SDK is available for free from Adobe's web site and it would do you well to check it out. It's truly encouraging to know that even if you've only done web development, you're not limited to the web alone, and all the work you put in on your site, can be reused to bring the same functionality offline.

Google Gears:

Google Gears gives developers another way of bringing an app offline. It is not a competitor for AIR, it is quite a different product and accomplishes different goals.

If you've used Google Docs, you will notice that they provide a facility to use the website even when offline, via a small link saying 'Offline' in the top right corner of the page. If you've never used it, here's what it does: it allows you to use Google Docs, even when you're disconnected from the internet. You'll still have all the same functionality, but you will be able to do everything you do in Google Docs, such as create a new document, or edit an existing document. These changes are stored locally on your computer, and when you go online, they are synchronised with the Google Docs server. Gmail also provides this facility now, however it needs to be turned on separately in Gmail Labs as it is still in development.

All Gears needs to function is a plug-in that is available for free in the Google Docs web site.

Many other technologies exist which leverage the power of AJAX, even for the facilities that the technologies above provide, many alternatives exist. All in all, learning how to harness the power of AJAX is a good idea even if you plan to